



Openfiler

Open-Source Storage Management

Many companies use the desktop version of a popular proprietary operating system for file sharing. The main constraint here is maximum limit of ten simultaneous connections to a single file share. The proprietary solution in this situation is to procure and deploy a server OS, and go on buying Client Access Licenses for each additional connected device. However, Openfiler, an Open Source Storage Management Appliance, can be used very effectively in this situation, to deliver fantastic functionality and granular access control.

We will try to appraise this interesting and feature-rich Linux distro in a series of articles. This first part covers basic Openfiler installation and configuration, and its various storage options for a 64-bit standard installation. Openfiler can convert any computer system complying with the minimum requirements to a storage server. The specifications, from the Openfiler website, are in Table 1.

The website further mentions that Openfiler is compatible with 32-bit and 64-bit industry standard server hardware too. It can also be installed in a virtual-machine environment such as VMWare or XenServer, as a guest OS. Future releases of Openfiler may only support 64-bit processors, so they are highly recommended for new Openfiler installations. Some important advantages of using Openfiler are:

- No licensing cost
- Multiple NIC bonding
- Support for iSCSI targets
- Software RAID support
- Remote replication for Disaster Recovery
- High Availability (HA) cluster fail-over capability

Openfiler also has various other features available on standard Network Attached Storage (NAS) boxes, including access via FTP, Web server and SMB/CIFS services; authentication against a local (or remote) LDAP server, or integration with a Windows domain controller; user/group-wise access control and quota management; configuration via

an easy Web-based GUI; free updates and patches. Help is available via excellent community support.

Getting started

To start exploring this wonderful distro, download your desired image from the Openfiler website. Various images are available: 32/64 bit ISOs, and various appliances for VMWare, VMWare ESX and Citrix XenServer. Our installation is based

Table 1: System specifications

Minimum Specifications:	Recommended Specifications (over the minimum specifications)
• 32-bit 1 GHz or higher-performance processor • 2 GB or more of RAM • 2 GB disk space for memory swap area • 8 GB disk space for Openfiler OS installation • 100 MB Ethernet network interface • Separate storage volumes/disks for data export	• 64-bit 1.6 GHz or higher-performance processor • 1 GB Ethernet network interface • Hardware RAID controller